

Wednesday, August 24

Cheryl had planned running around with the boys this morning. She took them to Premiere Optical and Sears to find frames for Peter's glasses. She bought white running shoes with a zipper that Peter would wear for gym and jeans that Peter liked "except for the stripes". Matthew was not easy to have along, and when Cheryl had come home at 1:30 she had "had it. The rest of my shopping will be done by catalogue." She said that Matthew had crawled out of his stroller and would not be put back in. Cheryl took the boys for lunch at The Bay. As she fed Matthew, Peter cried because he wanted to go to the bathroom. When the meal was done, Peter was still crying because "I have to go so badly," and Matthew pulled a chair over himself and screamed. I was working in peace on the writing project.

In the afternoon, Cheryl repaired a navy pantsuit, Matthew slept some and then spent the rest of the afternoon risking his life, I looked through English units for the fall and Peter played with Kelsey at her house. Kelsey had phoned twice at noon for Peter and engaged me in a volley of "byes" until I hung up on her. Peter was wearing his "guard" outfit. He blocked every doorway by stretching his arms across and saying "You can't go in there. There are prisoners in there" all in his harshest voice and frowningest look. He wears a microphone and speaker set strapped to a belt.

This morning he said, "Everybody in the world has died from germs Dr. Larsen put in their cereal, everybody except the people around here."

Cheryl's parents invited us out for supper at the Hospitality Inn as a payment for work done this weekend. Peter slept from 3:30 - 4:30. Cheryl sewed until after 5. We got the boys ready and left at 5:45. At the restaurant Peter spilled chocolate milk on the seats, himself and Mama. Everybody ordered filet mignon. Peter ordered King Crab legs. He enjoyed them but bore it with a philosophical reserve.

"Dad, I like crab. But I feel sorry that they have to be killed." He was watching the flame under his garlic butter and rested his chin on his knuckles. "But we need meat."

He ate most of it, shared the rest around the table, asked about the crab shell, metal lamps, and the procedure that brings crabs from the ocean to the table.

Matthew cried when the highchair he was pushing jammed against a table. I walked in the hallway with him. After supper we went to Cheryl's parent's place to pick up Peter. Peter mowed Papa's lawn with him. Matthew teased Vicky by sitting close to her and making her growl.

We left there by 8:30. A strong wind came up, whipped the trees and blew in heavy clouds to make a murky dusk. We drove to my parent's, visited for an hour, talked about family news, and drove home to put the boys to bed.

After Peter's nap, he was crouching on his hands and knees in the living room. Matthew walked to him and pushed him back and forth. Peter reached back and pulled Matthew down. They lay quietly for a minute and then stood up together. Peter walked into the kitchen and Matthew held onto his belt, leaning his forehead into Peter's back.

Matthew lay while in bed in his typical manner. Cheryl had the lights out and sat some distance away, near the door. Matthew was standing on blankets at the end of the crib. Cheryl asked him to lie down. Matthew disappeared as if he was lying down. Suddenly he popped up again and laughed. Down he would go, the dark top of his head visible, preparing to pull up again after a few seconds. We are never certain the silence will ever last more than that few seconds.